LIGERS OF GUJARAT

For all its pride in hosting the last redoubt of the Asiatic lion, Gujarat has suffered the absence of a stable population of resident tigers—unlike the neighbouring states of Rajasthan, MP and Maharashtra. All that is about to change with the announcement of a 28.96 hectare tiger safari park in the Dang district, which will be the new home for a population of eight zoo-bred big cats. While the beasts enjoy their new-found freedom, the development may lead to renewed calls for the Gujarat authorities to release some of their 500-odd lions to sanctuaries that have been designated for their reintroduction, in MP, Rajasthan and UP.





SHEKHAR PILLAY/ALAMY

HIGH GEAR

Sometimes referred to as the 'Little Kashmir', Pithoragarh shares a border with Nepal to the east and Tibet to the north. Be it trekkers wanting to get to the Milam glacier and Darma Valley, or pilgrims setting off for Kailash and Mansarovar, the district always proves to be a good start. Wanting more tourists to make their presence felt in the villages close to the India-China border, the Uttarakhand government has chosen Pithoragarh for yet another beginning. An adventure cycle rally is all set to be held here in the second week of May. Riding from Gunji to Adi Kailash, cyclists will cover a distance of 36 km and, with it, hope authorities, "vitalise border towns with such exercises".



GURPREET SINGH/GETTY IMAGES

ON A FAST TRACK

All of 30 kmph faster than the Shatabdi, the Vande Bharat Express boasts of more impressive features: European-style rotating seats, diffused LED lights, automatic doors, modular bio-vacuum toilets and sealed, dust-free gangways. Obviously pleased with this semi-high-speed train, the Centre has decided to add 400 Vande Bharats to its fleet. Presently only an option for people travelling between Varanasi, Delhi and Katra, the Vande Bharat Express (or 'Train 18', as it's also known) will soon connect New Delhi and Khajuraho, too. Railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw recently said, "Two rake points have been approved at Chhatarpur and Khajuraho. Tickets can now be obtained from 45,000 post offices."